

Chapter 109 - Extra: Three Years

Feng Yue's death caused the already restless Feng family to erupt like a dormant volcano suddenly awakening.

Jiang Xu¹ fainted from crying the moment Feng Yue drew her last breath, and although Jiang Shuyu² didn't lose consciousness, her face was streaked with tears.

And Yan Lin, standing foolishly at the hospital room door at that moment, was like someone who had been pressed on pause, frozen in place.

Just one second short.

Feng Yue had lost all signs of life one second before she appeared. No matter how hard the doctors tried to resuscitate her, Feng Yue could not be brought back to life.

Yan Lin stood there like a cold, detached observer, watching the chaos in the hospital room with indifferent eyes. To her, Feng Yue lying on the hospital bed without breath seemed not so much dead as simply asleep.

Yan Lin lifted her foot and walked in, her gaze deep as she looked at the person on the bed. This was the first time she had come to see Feng Yue since she had been transferred to the foreign hospital.

All traces of Feng Yue in the hospital room were still alive, but the person who should have been most alive had now closed her eyes forever.

Yan Lin didn't cry, nor was there any expression of grief on her face. She only felt that her body was very strange—it was as if a large stone had been pressed onto her heart, making it so heavy she could barely breathe.

Despite her physical discomfort, as the pillar of both families, Yan Lin still handled all the subsequent arrangements in her usual methodical manner.

From the moment she began handling Feng Yue's funeral arrangements, she became even more reluctant to speak. She would often stare at documents in a daze, her thoughts drifting to unknown places.

She felt like she was a dandelion seed carried by the wind, floating without a destination or return date.

Feng Yue's funeral was held domestically. Yan Lin stood there in pure black mourning clothes, accepting condolences from relatives and friends. She maintained that same expression, looking indifferently at all who came to pay their respects.

There were familiar faces and people she had never seen before, but without exception, all these people wore expressions of extreme sorrow, as if the deceased had been someone tremendously important to them.

But Feng Yue was supposed to be her wife.

Yan Lin watched all the crying people like an outsider. Seeing that these people could at least shed a few tears for Feng Yue, she confusedly raised her hand to touch her own cheek.

It was completely dry, without a trace of moisture.

Why wasn't she crying?

Yan Lin asked herself this question in her heart, and those who attended the funeral were also discussing this question privately.

Yan Lin had no answer, but those people cobbled together an answer of their own.

Because that Miss Yan from the Yan family didn't love her deceased wife at all! Not only had these two never even held a wedding ceremony, but that Miss Yan had never once brought her wife out to meet people.

Yan Lin leaned against the wall corner, pondering these people's words in her mind.

Did she not love Feng Yue? Yan Lin wasn't sure.

She only knew that she couldn't live without Feng Yue.

Daily meals of breakfast, lunch, and dinner became tasteless and bland. The warm little home became cold and eerily quiet. The bedroom that had once been filled with the scent of orange blossoms now only smelled of detergent.

Feng Yue's departure disrupted everything in Yan Lin's life, including herself.

This was Yan Lin's third visit to this psychology clinic.

"Miss Yan, you're here. Please have a seat."

"Thank you."

The doctor was an older woman. She flipped through Yan Lin's medical records and said, "Miss Yan, today shouldn't be your follow-up appointment day."

"Mm. It should be in three days."

"So, has something urgent happened?"

Yan Lin sat there calmly, not at all like a patient who should be appearing in a psychology clinic.

"I... saw her again."

Upon hearing this, the doctor straightened her expression. "Please describe it in detail."

"This time I saw her in the kitchen. She was still the same as before, cooking my favorite dishes in the kitchen, and she even chatted with me for a while. She didn't seem very happy though." Yan Lin's gaze grew distant, as if she were using her memories to recreate that moment of happiness.

"How did you come to your senses this time?"

"She was wearing that light yellow dress she really liked. I was afraid her dress would get dirty, so I wanted to put an apron on her. But when I turned around to look for an apron, I remembered that the pink apron she bought had been burned along with her other belongings. When I wanted to tell her we could buy another one, she had already disappeared."

The doctor nodded, picked up her pen to record something in her notebook, then asked, "Is your insomnia still severe?"

"I'm taking medication."

In the end, Yan Lin only returned home with medication for a new treatment cycle.

The small villa no longer contained anything Feng Yue had left behind, yet Yan Lin often saw her at home, just like before.

They would converse, dine, and rest as usual, but Yan Lin would always be pulled back to reality by some insignificant things. The moment she came to her senses, Feng Yue would disappear.

This situation continued for about a year, until the turning point came through Jiang Xu and Feng Hehai³.

After Feng Yue's death, Feng Hehai completely retired at home, handing all company matters over to Yan Lin while he stayed home to accompany Jiang Xu, whose mental state was deteriorating day by day.

But recently, Feng Hehai decided to take Jiang Xu and move to Vancouver, far away from this place of sorrow.

When Yan Lin learned of this news, she didn't react much, only silently arranged everything for the two elders in an even more subdued manner.

But on the day before the two elders left, Yan Lin saw Feng Yue once more.

Feng Yue was standing in the bedroom with an open suitcase at her feet, stuffing her clothes into it.

Yan Lin asked what she was doing, and Feng Yue told her she was going to Vancouver with her parents.

The joyful expression on that face was both familiar and strange to Yan Lin—she seemed not to have seen Feng Yue smile so happily in a very long time.

She heard herself ask: "What about me?"

Feng Yue's figure stood there. Although they were only separated by the distance of a suitcase, Yan Lin felt as if there were mountains and oceans between her and Feng Yue.

"I'm letting you go."

Yan Lin once again sat across from the psychologist, recounting her final story with "Feng Yue."

"Congratulations, Miss Yan. You will no longer experience such hallucinations. In your subconscious, Feng Yue has gone to live permanently in Vancouver with her parents."

"When she said she was letting you go, it was actually you letting yourself go."

Yan Lin walked out of the clinic and looked at the bustling street, feeling lost and confused for the first time.

Why did Feng Yue want to let her go, and why did she herself want to let herself go?

From that day forward, Yan Lin stopped taking sleeping pills and instead brought home a dim little night light from the mall.

She no longer saw Feng Yue, and with the company of the little night light, she never suffered from insomnia again. It was as if Feng Yue's existence had disappeared from her life entirely.

But only she knew that every day when she came home, she would say to the empty house, "I'm home."

What answered her was endless darkness and silence as thick as ink.

Yan Lin's life seemed to return to normal. In others' eyes, she was still that decisive and ruthless ruler of the Yan Group, and even she believed this herself.

But every night when she woke from dreams, all she touched was a pillow wet with moisture and the feeling of tears covering her face.

She couldn't remember what dreams she had, nor could she recall whom she had dreamed about.

She only knew that she had never been in such pain before. That feeling was like someone had torn open her chest alive and removed her beating heart.

So during this year, Yan Lin became increasingly gaunt. Jiang Shuyu and the household staff worried about her, trying various ways to fatten her up, but with little success.

Yan Lin grew thinner and thinner, but her aura became increasingly sharp. Almost no one at the Yan Group dared to make direct eye contact with this lofty ruler.

There was no emotion or light in Yan Lin's eyes. She was like a machine that never tired—work, work, and more work.

Until the day of Feng Yue's memorial.

She was driven to the cemetery by her chauffeur as usual, but there she saw Feng Yue's parents.

Jiang Xu had recovered considerably after two years of living abroad, but overall, both elders had aged significantly.

Yan Lin avoided the two until the elderly couple left, and only then did she appear at Feng Yue's tombstone with flowers.

In the memorial photo, Feng Yue's eyes sparkled with laughter, as if she were about to say something delightful in the next second.

But Yan Lin suddenly froze. It seemed she hadn't heard Feng Yue's voice in a very long time. What did Feng Yue's voice sound like?

Yan Lin had forgotten.

She remembered the words Feng Yue had said, but she had forgotten her voice.

Standing before the tombstone, Yan Lin felt momentarily dazed. This wasn't her first time visiting Feng Yue, but it was the first time she felt an overwhelming sense of futile boredom.

Life was boring, work was boring, living... was also extremely boring.

Yan Lin placed the flowers down and left the cemetery without a word. She had forgotten Feng Yue's voice; no matter what she said to Feng Yue now, she would never answer again.

A few days later, Yan Lin was detained in a downtown park due to some business matters, while her driver was rushing from over two hours away to pick her up.

So Yan Lin unusually found a bench in the park and sat down, stealing a moment to daydream.

Time passed, and the setting sun dyed half the sky red. Yan Lin stared straight ahead, where an elderly couple was taking a walk. The gray-haired pair held a small dog's leash and were chatting and laughing as they walked forward.

Yan Lin saw Feng Yue once more, and this time there was a familiar person beside Feng Yue.

It was herself.

The two were holding hands as they strolled, and "Yan Lin" was also holding a dog's leash.

They wandered around the park at a leisurely pace, chatting and laughing quite conspicuously.

The sun set and the figures dispersed. Yan Lin felt a drop of water land on the back of her hand. She snapped back to reality, looked at her hand, then raised it to touch her cheek.

It was completely wet.

She remembered. She remembered what she had dreamed about, remembered why she felt such pain when she woke up.

Because hidden in the deepest part of that heart that had been torn open and removed was—
Feng Yue.

—The End—

Footnotes:

¹ **Jiang Xu (江洳)** - Feng Yue's mother ² **Jiang Shuyu (蒋殊毓)** - Yan Lin's mother

³ **Feng Hehai (封鹤海)** - Feng Yue's father